

Jumbo's CIRCUS

By contesting all 590 constituencies at stake in the state polls, the BSP has begun its dry run for Elections 2009

| By Shafi Rahman |

On any given day, Kanwar Singh Tanwar, a Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) candidate for the Delhi Assembly, can be spotted moving around his constituency in one of his three Mercedes cars. With assets of over Rs 150 crore, Tanwar last week chose to feel the wind in his face as he rode an elephant on his way to file his nomination for the Chhattarpur assembly seat in the capital.

The richest MLA aspirant's caparisoned elephant won eyeballs and brought traffic to a halt on Chhattarpur's potholed roads. But his party has let loose the elephant—the BSP's electoral symbol—into the wilds of north Indian politics. The BSP is contesting all 590 seats at stake in Delhi, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh as a dry run for Mayawati's planned march to Race Course Road next year. Five years ago, it contested 387 seats and won only six but Mayawati believes she and the BSP have come a long way since last year's landslide victory in Uttar Pradesh.

Mayawati kicked off her poll campaign in Madhya Pradesh with an election rally at Khandwa during the week. In Delhi, the party was the first to announce candidates for all the seats. "Winning seats in the Delhi polls is important as a message will spread across the country ahead of

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Lok Sabha polls that Mayawati is prime minister material," says BSP Delhi President Brahm Singh Bidhuri. The ambitions may be national, but the issues remain local. "Price rise, complete statehood demand, basic amenities such as *bijli*, *sadak*, *paani* and unauthorised colonies are among the issues the BSP would be raising during the elections," Bidhuri says.

Not even die-hard BSP optimists think the party can win a handful of seats, if any, but its USP is the spoiler's role of poaching from the traditional votebank of the Congress—Dalits, Muslims and people hailing from eastern Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. It can effectively dent the chances of Congress candidates in nearly a dozen constituencies. In another 18 constituencies where 20 per cent of the voters are SCs, the BSP is again a threat to the

Grand Old Party. To gain cross-caste acceptance, as it did in Uttar Pradesh last year, the party has given 51 tickets to Brahmins, Gujjars, Jats, Vaishyas, Muslims, Khatri, Yadavs, Kshatriyas and Sikhs.

The elections will also put to test, albeit in a smaller way, the big ticket alliance between the Left and Mayawati. It will show how far Team Maya can go beyond the photo-ops with an impressive line-up and mark a nation-wide presence. The BSP has now grown beyond Uttar Pradesh into a party that is capable of upsetting other parties in at least 10 states including Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Punjab in next year's Lok Sabha polls. Its aim is to bag at least 80 seats in the General Elections. In the Uttar Pradesh assembly elections, it won 206 of the 403